

Non-Farm Employment Change – May 2026

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6/3/2026

ABSTRACT

Abstract The May 2026 employment data indicates a stable and resilient labor market, with nonfarm payrolls expanding by 172,000 jobs—virtually matching April’s strong, upwardly revised gains. The household survey reflects a steady labor supply, with the unemployment rate holding flat at 4.3% and the participation rate remaining unchanged at 61.8%. Headline growth was sustained by a significant shift in sector dynamics: a cooldown in private sector hiring (+120,000) was successfully counterbalanced by a sharp spike in government payrolls (+52,000), driven primarily by local government. Within the private sector, growth was highly concentrated in Leisure and Hospitality (+70,000) and Healthcare (+40,000), which offset ongoing contractions in Financial Activities (-22,000) and flatlining retail trends. Ultimately, the report depicts a mature labor market where robust public sector and service-driven hiring continue to anchor steady aggregate expansion.

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²Table 1: Overall Labor Market Summary (Household Survey Data)

Indicator	April 2026	May 2026	MoM	Trend Notes
Civilian Labor Force	169,995	170,078	+83	Held mostly steady over the month.
Employed	162,622	162,771	+149	Increased slightly after minor pullbacks earlier in the year.
Unemployed	7,373	7,307	-66	Changed very little over the month.
Unemployment Rate	4.3%	4.3%	0.0%	Unchanged. Range bound between 4.3% to 4.5% since July 2025.
Labor Force Participation Rate	61.8%	61.8%	0.0%	Flat. Participation rate showed little change over the entire past year.
Employment-Population Ratio	59.1%	59.2%	+0.1%	Unchanged MoM and YoY

³Table 2: Payroll Employment Changes by Sector & Industry Detail

Nonfarm Payroll Aggregates	April 2026	May 2026	MoM	Trend Notes
Total Nonfarm Payrolls	179	172	-7	Slight Growth
Total Private Payrolls	177	120	-57	Private sector hiring cooled relative to April
Government Payrolls	2	52	+50	Government hiring rose heavily to offset private sector's cooldown.
March Revision Note	185	214	+29	March job growth was higher
April Revision Note	115	179	+64	April job growth was revised up sharply by 64,000.

²This table captures the high-level, aggregate economic environment for May 2026 compared to April 2026. Numbers in thousands, seasonally adjusted

³ The BLS reported that previous months' payroll data saw substantial upward adjustments. Numbers in thousands, seasonally adjusted

⁴Payroll Employment Levels and Monthly Changes by Sector & Industry Detail

Sector & Industry	May 2026	April 2026	MoM	Trend Notes
TOTAL NONFARM PAYROLLS	164,064	163,892	+172	Steady expansion
Total Private Payrolls	139,640	139,520	+120	Private sector hiring cooled over the month.
GOODS-PRODUCING SECTORS	22,171	22,143	+28	Growth accelerated across commodity verticals
↳ Mining & Logging	651	647	+4	Gained net 10,000 jobs since February
↳ Construction	8,449	8,432	+17	Little change MoM
↳ Manufacturing	13,071	13,064	+7	Marginal gains
↳ Durable goods	8,129	8,112	+17	+3.6k pickup in Motor vehicles and parts
↳ Nondurable goods	4,942	4,952	-10	Minor downward trend line
PRIVATE SERVICE-PROVIDING	117,469	117,377	+92	Softened relative to April due to retail and shipping reversals
↳ Wholesale Trade	6,307	6,311	-3.7	Minimal momentum
↳ Retail Trade	15,643	15,644	-1.1	Flat
↳ Transportation & Warehousing	6,513	6,512	+0.6	Transit/ground passenger transportation (+9k) and warehousing (+6k), but dragged by air transportation drop (-9k).
↳ Information	3,020	3,022	-2	Flat
↳ Financial Activities	9,104	9,126	-22	Contracting. Down 107,000 jobs from its May 2025 peak. Insurance carriers (-11k) and commercial banking (-3k)
↳ Professional & Business Services	23,247	23,241	+6	Relatively flat
↳ Private Education & Health Services	28,682	28,642	+40	Continual growth. Health care expanded by 35k & Social assistance by 12k.
↳ Leisure & Hospitality	16,992	16,922	+70	Strongest outperformer. May growth beat its 12 month trailing average (+14k). Food services and drinking places represent 48,000 of the total gain
↳ Other Services	5,960	5,957	+3	Minor fluctuations
GOVERNMENT	24,424	24,372	+52	Driven heavily by Local government, excluding education which added 44,000 jobs

⁴ This version provides the actual volume of employed workers for both April and May 2026, followed by the net velocity and trend trajectory notes from the BLS.

Levels and changes are in thousands, seasonally adjusted

